

# Cook and Levi 1990 Claude Guide

Cook, Karen Schweers, and Margaret Levi, eds. *The Limits of Rationality*.  
Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1990.

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# 1 Status of This Guide

**Partial guide — verify before relying on it.** This is an *edited volume*, not a monograph, and unlike the other guides in this folder it has been written without the book to hand. The framing below (the volume’s central question, its place in the literature, and its relationship to the rest of your reading list) is solid. What is deliberately *absent* is a chapter-by-chapter breakdown: attributing specific arguments to specific contributors from memory is exactly the kind of claim that is easy to get subtly wrong and costly to repeat in an exam.

Fill in the chapter sections from the table of contents when you have the volume, and delete this note.

## 2 Central Claims

- The volume is an interrogation, from broadly sympathetic insiders, of **how far rational choice explanation can be pushed** in the social sciences, and of where and why it breaks down. The contributors are not external critics dismissing rational choice; the project is to locate its boundary conditions.
- The organizing move is that the standard rational actor model—self-interested, consistent preferences, maximizing over known options—is a **useful idealization whose failures are systematic rather than random**. Because they are systematic, they are themselves theorizable, and the interesting work lies in specifying when the model holds and what supplements it when it does not.
- Recurring candidate limits across the volume: **cognitive constraints** (bounded rationality, framing effects, heuristics); **norms, values, and commitments** that are not reducible to instrumental calculation; **social structure and embeddedness**, which shape both preferences and available options; and **collective action and cooperation** outcomes that narrow self-interest predicts poorly.
- A methodological through-line: the tension between **methodological individualism** and explanations that require supra-individual entities (norms, institutions, structures) to do real explanatory work.

## 3 Why It Sits on the Reading List

- It is a **hinge text** for questions about the microfoundations of comparative politics. Much of your list runs on rational choice machinery; this volume asks what that machinery can and cannot carry.
- Levi’s own research program—on consent, compliance, and quasi-voluntary cooperation with the state—makes her a useful bridge between rational choice and the institutional and normative accounts elsewhere on the list.

- Cook brings the social exchange and social structure tradition in sociology, which supplies the “embeddedness” critique in a form more rigorous than the usual gestures at culture.

## 4 Connections to Your Other Readings

- **Olson 1965**: the canonical statement of the collective action problem that this volume complicates. Where Olson derives free-riding from narrow self-interest, the limits-of-rationality literature asks why cooperation is nonetheless so common.
- **Ostrom 1990** (same year): the strongest empirical answer to that question—common-pool resource users building institutions that sustain cooperation. Reading these two together is the natural pairing: Ostrom shows the anomaly, this volume theorizes it.
- **North 1990** (also same year): institutions as constraints on choice, plus North’s own concession that ideology and informal norms do explanatory work that pure rational choice cannot.
- **Scott 1985**: peasant resistance as behavior that looks irrational under a narrow model but is intelligible once norms, dignity, and risk are taken seriously.
- **Putnam 1993**: social capital and trust as the kind of supra-individual resource that strains methodological individualism.
- **Svolik 2012** and **Kalyvas 2006**: both push rational choice into hard cases (authoritarian power-sharing, wartime violence); useful for arguing about where the model earns its keep.
- **Weber**: the *Zweckrational* / *Wertrational* distinction is the ancestor of this entire debate—instrumental versus value rationality, with the latter irreducible to the former.

## 5 Likely Exam Uses

- As the **citation for the boundary condition**: when an answer leans on a rational choice mechanism, this volume is the acknowledgment that the mechanism has known limits, which is usually worth more than pretending it does not.
- As a **bridge between literatures**, letting you move from rational choice arguments to institutional or normative ones without the transition looking like a change of subject.
- In answers about **microfoundations**: what does a macro-level claim about regimes or institutions actually assume about individual behavior, and is that assumption doing legitimate work?

## 6 Chapter Notes

*To be completed from the volume's table of contents — see the status note above.*

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